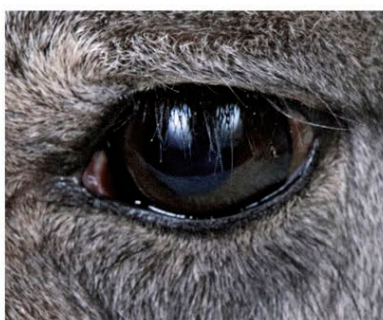
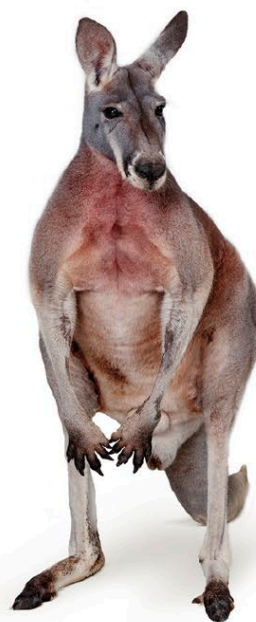


RED KANGAROO

Osphranter rufus

Kangaroos evolved in Australia, filling the niche occupied elsewhere by grazing animals such as antelope. In common with those species, kangaroos have a big stomach to take on large quantities of grass. Living out in the open is risky for all herbivores, and kangaroos share with antelope a number of adaptations for avoiding predators. They live in herds (called mobs), have sharp senses, are tall enough to scan their surroundings for danger, and possess a wonderful turn of speed. The red is the largest and swiftest kangaroo, able to hop at more than 50 km (30 miles) an hour. Only the female has a pouch, in which she carries her young – known as a joey – for the first seven months of its life. Red kangaroos are well adapted to drought – they are able to eat scrubby saltbush, which is toxic to other animals.

SIZE 0.7–1.4 m (2¼–4½ft)
HABITAT Scrubland, desert
DISTRIBUTION Australia
DIET Herbivorous

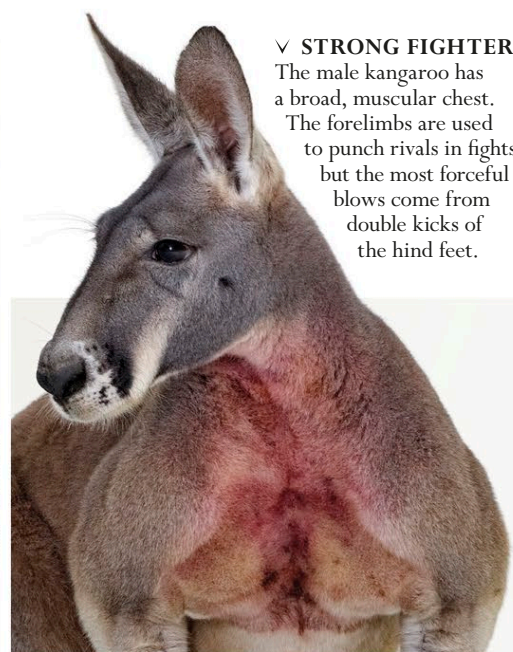
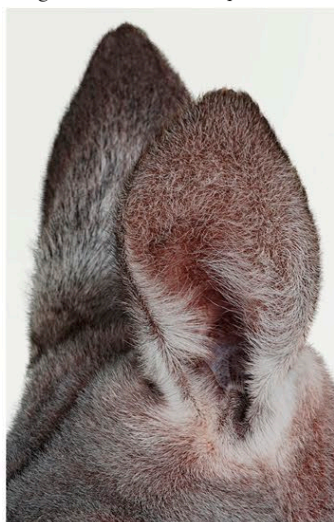


< EYE

The eyes are widely spaced towards the sides of the head, giving a very wide field of vision. This aids the kangaroo's awareness of predators.

> EARS

The ears are large and sensitive, and can be swivelled in different directions to focus on sounds that might mean danger is approaching.



✓ STRONG FIGHTER

The male kangaroo has a broad, muscular chest. The forelimbs are used to punch rivals in fights, but the most forceful blows come from double kicks of the hind feet.



^ CLAWS

The feet have surprisingly sharp claws. These provide grip when hopping, but also serve as weapons, and as combs for grooming.

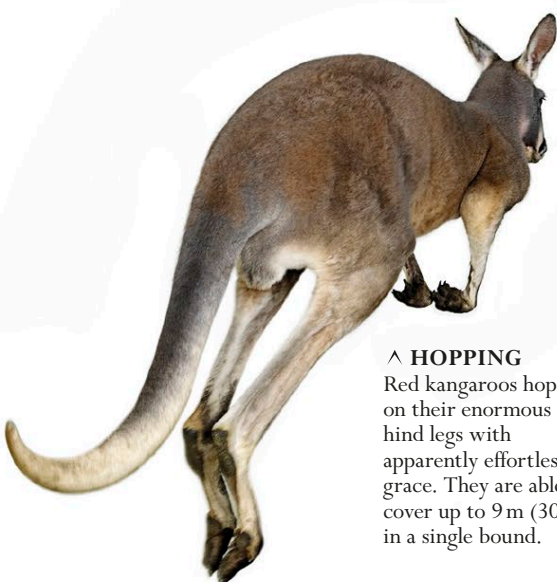


< ✓ HIND FOOT

The scientific name *Macropus* literally means "big foot". Each hind foot has four toes: an outer, weight-bearing pair, and an inner pair used for grooming.



tail acts as a counterbalance when hopping, and as a supportive fifth limb when standing still



^ HOPPING

Red kangaroos hop on their enormous hind legs with apparently effortless grace. They are able to cover up to 9 m (30 ft) in a single bound.